staggering 10 million people at its peak.[2] Mass migrations due to the partitions are etched in public memory in India's border-states as their ramifications persist even now. On a smaller scale, Tibet and Kashmir also witnessed intimidation, persecution and exodus. Yet, these events and other partitions are dwarfed by the fact that more than 40 million people have been displaced *within* India due to development-related projects since Independence.[3] Collectively, all these events shaped the contours of involuntary migration with words like 'refugee', 'relief', 'rehabilitation', and 'DPs' or 'Displaced Persons' entering the common vocabulary.

The Partition of 1937: Burma

The first major partition of British India took place in 1937, when Burma was constitutionally separated amidst strong native voices calling for political representation and restrictions on the flow of Indian migrants. Ever since its integration with British India in 1886, people of the Indian subcontinent had full access to the Burmese labour market across multiple sectors and occupations, riding on the Great Indian Migration Wave. By the 1930s, there were around 1 million people of Indian origin in Burma, constituting 7 per cent of the total population and over half the population of Rangoon city.[4] During the Great Depression, the Burmese economy sank as rice exports shrunk, jobs dried up and allegations of Indian usurpation sprang forth. In addition to the interests of Chettiar capital, as noted in a previous chapter, even labour migrants were targeted by locals. In 1930, racial riots broke out near the Rangoon docks between Indian and Burmese labourers, killing dozens and injuring hundreds. What began as a quarrel over jobs and wages spiralled into a rallying cry for restrictive immigration policies by nationalists. Anti-migrant sentiment and a weak economy dampened migration flows from the Indian subcontinent to Burma over the next decade.

On 23 December 1941, Rangoon was bombed by Japan amidst World War II hostilities.[5] The attack was sudden and caught the British off guard. As the British army retreated, civilians of non-Burmese origin, mostly from